

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Executive Quality Dashboard

Frame the same quality data for executives — as risk, trend and decisions — without drowning them in QA detail.

Purpose

An executive quality dashboard presents quality as a business concern — risk, trend and the decisions that follow — rather than as QA activity. Its central idea is that different audiences need different information from the same underlying data. An executive needs to know whether quality is helping or hurting the business objectives and what decision is being asked of them. A squad needs the granular signals that tell them what to fix this week. Show an executive the team view and they disengage; show a team the executive view and they cannot act. This template makes the translation deliberate.

When to use it

- For a recurring leadership or board update on quality, alongside delivery and growth.
- When an executive sponsor wants "faster, safer releases" but has no shared definition of either — the dashboard supplies one.
- When you are arguing for investment (headcount, tooling, time) and must frame quality as risk and ROI, not as QA workload.
- Whenever you catch yourself pasting a team burndown into an exec deck — that is the signal you need this.

Instructions

1. Start from the business objectives, not the metrics. At Northstar: ship faster without more incidents; make the public API dependable enough to sell against SLAs; control cost.
2. For each objective, choose one or two outcome metrics from the QA Metrics Catalogue that speak directly to it.
3. Show status as direction and risk (improving/steady/worsening, and a RAG), not raw numbers an executive cannot calibrate.
4. For every red or worsening item, state the decision or support you are asking for. An executive dashboard without asks is just noise.
5. Keep it to one screen. If it needs scrolling, it is a team view wearing an executive badge.
6. Maintain the detailed team view separately, and be ready to drill into it if asked — but do not lead with it.

Worked example

The same reporting period at Northstar, shown two ways. First the executive view: outcomes, trend, and asks, tied to business objectives. The trend words describe direction only — no invented figures.

Business objective	Quality signal	Status	Trend	Decision / ask
Ship faster without more incidents	Escaped defects & production incidents	Amber	Improving	Continue earlier QA involvement; no ask this period
Ship faster without more incidents	Change failure rate	Red	Steady	Approve a shared release quality gate across squads
Dependable public API for SLAs	Risk coverage of API critical paths	Amber	Improving	Endorse API contract-test investment over more UI tests
Control cost	Regression cost (5-day manual pass) & automation trust	Red	Worsening	Fund targeted automation of critical journeys; retire flaky UI tests
Overall	Confidence in shipping safely	Amber	Improving	On track if the two asks above are supported

Now the team view of the very same underlying data — granular, actionable, and exactly what would lose an executive's attention.

Metric	This period	Owner	Action this sprint
Escaped defects by squad	Payments highest; Web lowest	Squad QA leads	Root-cause the Payments escapes at retro
Flaky-test rate (UI suite)	~25% of ~1,800 tests	Dan Whitmore	Quarantine top 50 flaky tests; stop them blocking merges
Pipeline feedback time	~6-hour UI run	Platform + QA	Split suite; run critical subset on PR
Defect ageing	Backlog of ageing low-severity defects	Squad leads	Triage and close or accept stale defects
Regression pass duration	~5 days manual before major releases	QA team	Identify top 20 journeys to automate first
Environment stability	Shared staging unstable	Platform team	Escalate isolated test-data environment

The two tables are drawn from one data set. The executive table answers "is quality helping the business, and what do you need from me?". The team table answers "what do I fix on Tuesday?". Neither could stand in for the other, and that is the entire point.

Blank reusable version

Executive view:

Business objective	Quality signal	Status (R/A/G)	Trend	Decision / ask

Business objective	Quality signal	Status (R/A/G)	Trend	Decision / ask
Overall				

Team view:

Metric	This period	Owner	Action this sprint

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Showing executives the team's operational metrics and losing the room; presenting numbers with no direction and no ask, so leaders cannot tell good from bad or what to do; using QA jargon (test cases, flaky, coverage percentages) an executive cannot calibrate; a dashboard so dense it needs scrolling; and reporting status with no link to the business objectives leaders are actually measured on.

- Colouring things green to look good, then having no credibility when something goes red.
- Never asking for anything, so quality reads as a status update rather than a lever the business can pull.

How to interpret the results

- Read the executive view as "objective at risk?" and "decision required?". If nothing is asked for, either everything is genuinely fine or the dashboard is hiding something.
- Trend direction matters more to an executive than the absolute value — "worsening" on a green metric deserves attention before "steady" on a red one.
- Red plus a clear ask is a healthy dashboard; red with no ask means you have not finished thinking.
- If an executive keeps drilling into detail, your outcome framing is not yet convincing — tighten the link to their objectives.
- Consistency period to period lets leaders track your quality story like any other business trend, which is exactly the credibility you want.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Rehearse the one-sentence headline before you build the dashboard: "Quality is improving and on track, and I need two decisions from you to keep it that way." If you cannot say that sentence, you are not ready to present — and no amount of well-formatted tables will rescue a report that has no point of view.